The Bottleneck in B2B Trade
From Conversation to Transaction

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Foreword

Directly out of college, I helped scale a wholesale supplier with roughly $20 million in revenue. The business encompassed a manufacturing division and a wholesale pipeline. In parallel, a separate company sold direct-to-consumer. Orders came in over the phone. Inventory lived across spreadsheets and sticky notes, and tracking was mostly improvised. The average order to fulfillment touched 27 unique tools and people re-keyed between siloed systems all day.

I thought we were light-years behind, so I built an Airtable with some automation. In 2016, this was a cutting edge solution.

Over the next decade I spent time in both large and small supplier relationships, across both B2B and B2C channels. I learned the bottlenecks from my first job were implicit across industry. I worked with the world's largest paper products manufacturer Tork (Essity), BMW Group, Shell fuel, Newell Brands, and even CPG projects at Redbull. These companies have billions in revenue and massive technology budgets, but are bottlenecked by the same fragmented ordering integrations, spreadsheets and manual re-keys. The larger the company, the more duct tape is afforded. Having the tools and being able to use them efficiently are completely different things. Duct tape works faster than behavioral change, and it's cheaper.

Even as wholesale trade digitized in the 2010s, tools remained siloed. That's because the most critical transaction layer, where the order originates, remains largely offline.

This is a behavioral phenomenon, not a technical one. Since the 1800s, merchants have made wholesale orders through field sales representatives who carried samples, catalogues, and order books. That practice predates modern eCommerce by over 150 years.

Today, B2B ordering looks largely like it did 20 years ago in the first wave of digitization. For suppliers, the experience is manual, slow, and fragmented at every step. For the buyer, it's error-prone and different across each supplier. Buyers often don't know what they're getting until it shows up. They might receive a payment link in 30 days by email. Or maybe a paper invoice shows up in the mailroom. Suppliers are constantly chasing their money. U.S. suppliers carry trillions in aggregate accounts receivable at any given time.

So wholesale trade consists of two sides with the same slow, opaque and high-risk pain. I spent the past year embedded in the buyer end of wholesale operations to see just how deep that pain goes, and to explore how infrastructure can better adapt to market needs.

While ERP adoption has grown, even among small suppliers, the transaction workflow hasn't codified around a shared source of truth. Orders still come through email threads and phone calls. Most companies reconcile in disconnected systems. Many treat their ERPs like an order management tool, hacked into roles it was never designed to fill. The ledger has evolved substantially but the transaction has not.

This stagnation is why I'm fascinated by B2B trade. This is one of the largest economic systems in the world, yet it remains one of the least modernized. And it's probably the final frontier of the internet economy. Every other category has been rebuilt on structured, programmable rails. Wholesale tools exist, but they're not efficient to use because they can't communicate. And until recently, the supplier pipeline remained too offline to bridge these siloes effectively.

The next decade of innovation here will reshape how global commerce functions.

This paper maps the forces behind that shift. It explains why B2B workflows resisted modernization for two decades, why the point of sale is the structural bottleneck and why it is the only viable starting point for transforming an unstructured analog market into a real-time digital rail.

In 2035, every B2B transaction will be structured, financed, and reconciled in real time. Buyers will search, evaluate, and order through a single conversational flow.

Definitions

Supplier Segmentation and Market Scope:

The analysis in this paper focuses on the suppliers that sit in the middle of the B2B landscape. To keep definitions clear, it is useful to establish three revenue bands that map to how researchers and financial institutions describe the market.

At the base of the market are small suppliers. These are SMBs with less than ten million dollars in annual revenue. They are often owner-operator led, serving a single region or niche and rely heavily on manual tools such as spreadsheets, email, and basic accounting software. In mature economies they represent the long tail of wholesale and manufacturing activity.

Above them sit mid-market suppliers. Across the National Center for the Middle Market, large banks, and corporate finance literature, the middle market is defined as companies with roughly ten million to one billion dollars in annual revenue. Some sources further split this band into lower middle market at ten to fifty million, core middle at fifty to five hundred million, and upper middle at five hundred million to one billion. This segment accounts for about one third of private sector revenue and employment in the United States and includes many of the wholesalers, distributors, and manufacturers that anchor regional and national supply chains.

Above the middle market are large suppliers with more than one billion dollars in revenue. These are global brands and enterprise scale manufacturers that typically run custom EDI connections, proprietary ordering portals, and heavily engineered internal systems.

This paper is primarily concerned with the lower and core middle market supplier, roughly 10 to 100 million in annual revenue. Firms in this band are large enough to face real operational complexity and to serve many independent buyers, but small enough that they rarely have in-house engineering teams or custom transaction tools. These SMB and mid-tier suppliers represent the majority of U.S. wholesale trade establishments and a majority share of industry revenue.

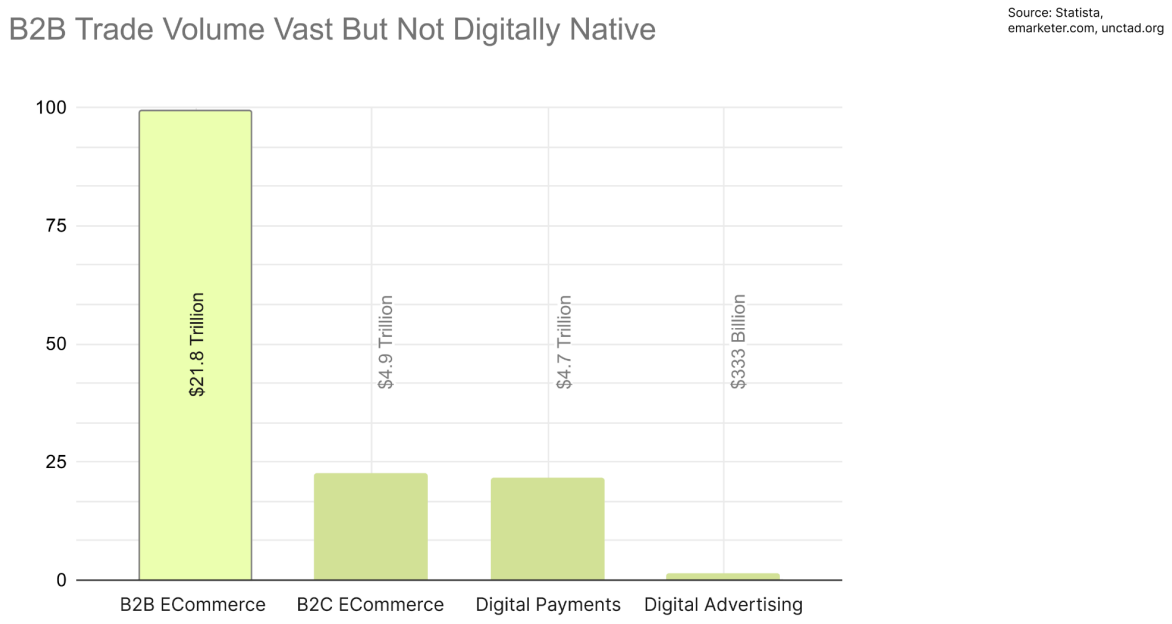
The middle market is where the system bottlenecks are most visible, and where a shift to real time, structured transactions has the greatest impact.

Section 1

The Historical Freeze. Why B2B Stayed Offline

B2B stagnated because there was no pain strong enough to force change. The system was inefficient but stable. Since no competitive surface emerged, relationships remained sticky, and manual processes remained economically rational.

Over the past twenty years, nearly every major category of the internet economy has transitioned to structured, connected digital workflows. Payments moved to plug-and-play facilitators. Consumer commerce adopted click-to-buy. Logistics moved to API-driven carriers. B2B transactions, despite being larger than all of them in aggregate, did not.

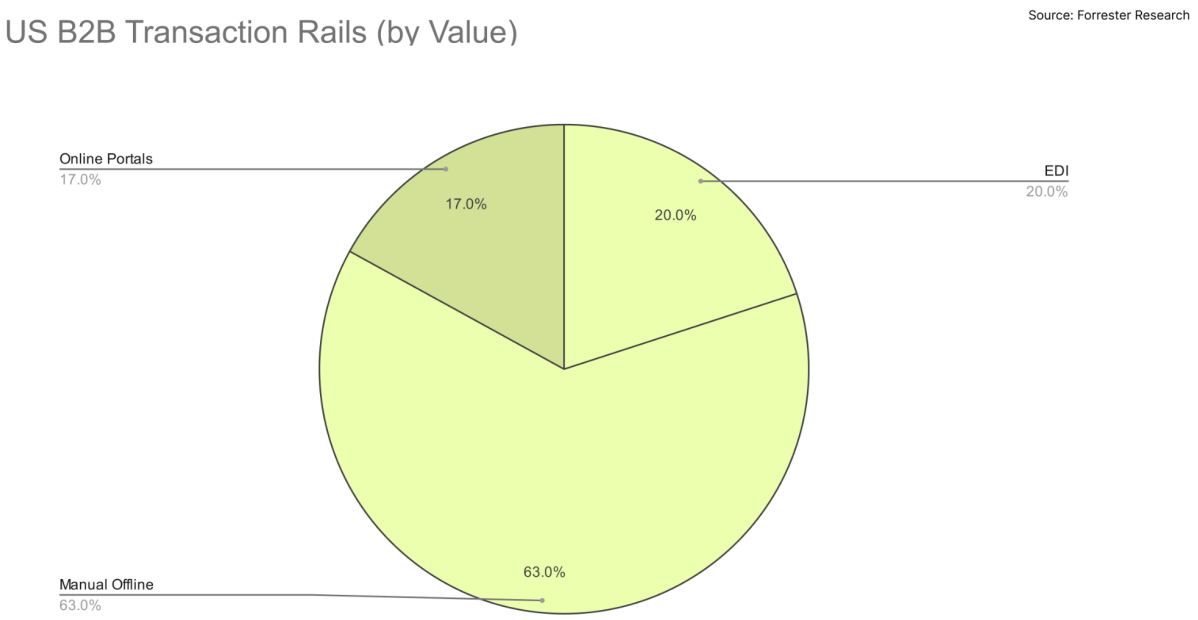


While a large share of B2B transaction *value* is routed through electronic systems like EDI, these systems are structurally distinct from the real-time digital workflows that define other internet-native markets.

B2B has a unique structural resistance to automation. Transactions are low-volume and high-stakes, procurement processes require institutional oversight, and order surfaces remain offline. This prevents the source of truth required for digital optimization.

For suppliers, the transaction rail begins in one of three forms:

1. **Offline and unstructured**: Email threads, phone calls, PDFs, spreadsheets
2. **Semi-structured (EDI)**: Rigid and expensive legacy formats used only by larger enterprises
3. **Online portals**: Inconsistent, isolated interfaces that never reached scale



Offline methods dominate because the underlying incentives remain unchanged. In other markets, modernization became necessary for survival. Consumer commerce platforms emerged because online convenience became a competitive requirement. That forced payments and logistics to automate. Then digital media fragmentation compressed margins and forced advertising into programmatic tools.

B2B had no equivalent forcing function. Wholesale trade is characterized by low volume, high value transactions. This is an important distinction because manual processes remain economically rational far longer than in other categories. Human oversight on a $50,000 order makes sense; human oversight in a $50 consumer purchase does not. Relationships have been stable, and high switching costs discourage experimentation. Only recently have buyers established demand for digital ordering tools.

Markets evolve when the pain of stagnation exceeds the cost of evolution. Historically, B2B felt no such pain.

Structural barriers reinforce the stagnation. Most critically, the order surface is phone calls, email and field sales. Since the transaction origin is unstructured, every downstream workflow needs to be manually structured (a dynamic explored in the next section). This prevents the creation of shared data layers that optimization tools require., meaning no measurable feedback loops for compounding improvements.

Over the past 20 years, ERP adoption increased dramatically across SMB and mid-market suppliers. This brought discipline to inventory management, cost tracking, and accounting. But it did not

modernize the transaction layer or eliminate manual quoting and confirmation steps. And in many cases, suppliers treat their ERP as a makeshift order management system, bolting on spreadsheets or forms to bridge gaps. So while the internal ledger has evolved, the buyer-supplier interaction has not.

Efficiency tools alone cannot change market behavior. For that to happen, tools must unlock financial and competitive value (Section 6).

Even as adjacent infrastructure modernized (logistics APIs, embedded payments, cloud systems), the front line of B2B remained untouched. The market was too fragmented for any single platform to impose standards. No shared schema existed, which made interoperability impossible. Without interoperability, network effects never emerged, and no single rail could gain traction.

This is the historical freeze: a market that remains offline not because the technology is unavailable, but because the conditions for change never materialized. The system was inefficient, but it worked.

That stability is now ending. Conditions that prevented modernization for two decades are shifting, and B2B is entering a period where structured digital rails will become not just viable, but necessary.

Section 2
The Friction Lattice: Where the Current System Breaks

Operational pain in B2B originates at the transaction layer. Because orders begin as unstructured inputs distributed across email, spreadsheets, attachments, and human memory, the workflow is heavily reliant on manual translation. This chapter maps the specific points where that translation occurs and shows why these failures compound into systemic friction.

Section 1 explained why there was no forcing function to drive modernization. Section 2 examines what happens operationally when the point of sale stays offline, why the workflow breaks, and why individual suppliers could not resolve these failures on their own

The defining characteristic of B2B transactions is that most orders begin with unstructured input. When the transaction originates offline, that lack of structure propagates into every downstream process. The result is a predictable set of failures across four layers of the ordering lifecycle. Each layer introduces manual work that compounds with the next, requiring consistent human interpretation.

Layer 1: Transaction Friction:

The first point of friction is the transaction itself. To create a single order, a rep pulls information from several disconnected sources. Availability sits in the ERP, while pricing and discount tiers are usually stored in historical quotes or internal files. Variant definitions live in catalog documents. Delivery constraints live in separate tools or notes. Few of these sources communicate with one another, and practically none are accessible to the buyer in real time. Because order information is scattered, the transaction begins with ambiguity. Every attribute requires human input and manual validation before the order can be confirmed.

The American Productivity & Quality Center (APQC) benchmarks the cost of processing a single purchase order manually between $50-$506, based on organizational maturity. But suppliers that use automated processes reduce their cycle times, and commensurate labor cost per order by 46%.

Layer 2: Workflow Friction:

The second point of friction is workflow fragmentation. Once a rep assembles a working version of the order, the transaction moves through sales, finance, and operations. Each domain works in a different system and maintains its own representation of the transaction.

Sales takes the buyer's input and converts it into an order record. This is the least standardized process of the transaction workflow, varying heavily from organization to organization and even more between individual operators. Finance then applies credit rules, assigns terms, and prepares invoices based on its own interpretation of that record. Operations translates the same information into pick tickets, packing lists, and shipment data. These processes are not aligned to a common transaction schema, and changes made in one system can't propagate cleanly to the others.

Every domain also triggers its own downstream tasks that occur in parallel, but remain disconnected. This forces a manual update cycle, and commensurate lift across multiple systems, each introducing new opportunities for mismatches and delay. Consider that Salesforce research shows sales reps spend only 28% of their time actually selling. The other 72% is lost to this manual admin work.

Layer 3: Financial Friction:

Like other transaction-driven categories, the financial lifecycle in B2B is expected to follow the operational lifecycle. Credit evaluation should occur when the order is formed.

1. Terms should reflect the defined transaction.
2. Invoicing should be generated from the confirmed order.
3. Payment and cash application should match shipped goods.
4. Revenue recognition should map to fulfillment.

In practice, this flow is rarely achieved. Credit decisions are made outside the transaction layer on either a negotiated basis or according to volume-based tiers. Rep-managed CSVs are overwhelmingly the tool of record, and reps often develop personal systems that are passed down human to human rather than standardized at an organization level.

As a result, terms are applied based on information that may or may not reflect current account status, actual payment behavior, or fiscal exposure. Invoicing generally occurs only after operational work is complete and often through separate tools that do not connect cleanly to the systems used for quoting or fulfillment. Payment timing frequently diverges from shipment timing, and revenue recognition does not consistently track actual delivery.

The scale of suppliers' exposure is significant. At any given time, U.S. suppliers carry an estimated $5.6 Trillion in revolving unsecured trade credit. When limits, terms, and accounts receivable collections are managed through disconnected workflows, suppliers accept unnecessary risk. Mid-market suppliers operate in a constant cash chase cycle: following up on overdue balances, correcting invoices and resolving disputes that originate from mismatched records rather than true counterparty risk.

The buyer's experience reflects similar fragmentation. Because credit terms are negotiated supplier by supplier and stored inconsistently, buyers have no standardized way to see available credit, manage exposure, or reconcile status across their supplier base. Each relationship operates on a unique set of rules and within a different surface.

In recent years, fintech providers have begun offering credit-intermediation services to address this gap. Resolve Pay and Apruve, for example, enable suppliers to extend net terms while shifting credit risk and collections to a third party. These platforms accept orders, advance cash to suppliers within 24 hours, and manage invoicing and payments on the supplier's behalf. Suppliers get cash now and offload risk, while buyers gain a mechanism to self-manage credit positions or apply payments in a unified way. This is meaningful progress, but adoption remains limited because these systems

operate on their own rails and do not integrate cleanly across the broader ordering and fulfillment workflow.

Layer 4: Communication Friction:

The fourth point of friction is communication. The buyer and supplier exchange clarifications and adjustments across channels that are not connected to the systems used to store the order. Partial lists, old quotes, product substitutions, and exceptions do not live on a unified record. Reps hold critical information in text messages, email threads, or memory. When adjustments occur, there is usually no authoritative transaction file that updates consistently across the organization. Each participant sees a slightly different version of the order, meaning accuracy is dependent on individual judgment rather than system logic.

These four friction layers compound to reinforce one another. The result is a lattice of interdependent failures driven by a single underlying condition: the transaction does not begin as structured data.

The consequence is a system where translation work absorbs capacity that should be spent on execution. Cycle times depend on individual performance rather than system reliability. The friction in B2B is the predictable outcome of starting every transaction offline, and no individual supplier can resolve it by optimizing downstream. The constraint is at the source.

Section 3

The Point of Sale Gap

Because the Point of Sale stayed offline, ordering produced communication rather than events that could be optimized. Suppliers couldn't measure buyer behavior, so incremental improvements don't compound.

Section 2 mapped downstream consequences. This section looks upstream. The Point of Sale (POS) is the strategic center of B2B trade because it is the only surface where the buyer-supplier relationship becomes a formal transaction. Every commitment in trade (quantity, pricing, availability, terms, timing) is shaped here.

Because this layer stayed offline, optimization culture never penetrated B2B.

In a period of roughly one decade, consumer eCommerce evolved from static product listings to predictive conversion engines. By the 2020s, real-time A/B testing, personalized recommendations, and dynamic pricing had become table stakes. Platforms like Shopify, BigCommerce, and Amazon gave even small merchants access to analytics dashboards that tracked every click, cart addition, and abandonment. The infrastructure assumed measurement; sellers competed on optimization. While technology enabled consumer eCommerce adoption, its sustained growth (eCommerce now accounts for >16% of all US retail sales) is driven by this culture of optimization. That is, a business methodology that focuses on compounding incremental gains across various connected platforms.

In consumer eCommerce, a fractional lift in conversion rate, a slightly faster checkout, or more accurate recommendations produce a measurable revenue impact. For example, a $10M eCommerce channel could see $1M growth from just a 0.2% increase in conversion rate and a $5 increase in Average Order Value (AOV). That's because the entire buying journey occurs on a digital platform. Every signal feeds a feedback loop of structured and observable events that can be tested.

The result is that consumer eCommerce has codified around three universal levers, which sellers work relentlessly to optimize. These are Customers, Frequency and AOV: how many people buy, how often they return, and how much they spend.

B2B never entered a similar cycle. Because most purchases don't touch a digital interface until after they are confirmed, operators view buyers as relationships, but not ones that are programmable en-masse. Discovery, evaluation, and ordering lives in conversations and manually prepared documents. The systems that log orders receive only the final reconstruction of the transaction, but not the buyer actions that led to it. Without a stream of structured signals (views, adjustments, clarifications, drop-off points) B2B surfaces lack signals to analyze and improve.

To date, suppliers have focused on catalog operations and customer relationship management because those are the levers they can influence in a vacuum. Operational improvements mattered, but they did not compound the way digital improvements do when a system can see and measure buyer behavior.

A structured POS resolves these problems, but only if the structure originates with the buyer. The order must enter the system as a digital event at the moment of intent, not as a reconstruction after the fact. Cycle time compresses because there is no longer a gap between what the buyer asked for and what the system understands. Suppliers can intentionally test, validate and optimize the buyer journey.

The order lifecycle becomes predictable, measurable, and programmable.

Section 4
B2B's Behavioral Reality

Conversational interfaces are the inflection point that brings B2B transactions online. For the first time, the behavior that has defined B2B ordering for two centuries can exist on a digital surface

Section 3 established that structure must originate with the buyer. In B2B, that behavior has existed on analog surfaces for 150 years. This section explores why the technology to make those conversations structured is now becoming viable.

One of the most misunderstood parts of the modernization story is that B2B is not behind because of culture, age, or reluctance to adopt new tools. The deeper truth is that the market never had the interface needed for modernization to take hold. For the first time, the behavior that has defined B2B ordering for nearly two centuries can be brought onto a digital surface. And B2B, not B2C, is the market most naturally positioned to adopt it first.

This runs counter to the conventional narrative that consumer behavior leads and B2B follows. For most technology waves, that has been true. But conversational interfaces are a rare exception because the behavioral adaptation required for wholesale trade is almost zero.

Consumer commerce has trained buyers for two decades to browse and click. They learned to navigate interfaces, research, compare products visually, then walk through checkout funnels. Moving these behaviors into a conversational model – where a buyer types or speaks their order – requires a complete reset. It asks consumers to abandon patterns that have been shaped by 20 years of interface design.

B2B buyers never adopted those patterns in the first place.

In wholesale trade, every meaningful step in the purchasing workflow already happens through conversation. Buyers message reps and ask questions about compatibility and availability. Together they align on pricing and clarify product details. They check lead times and confirm final quantities. For nearly two centuries, the "interface" in B2B has been a threaded conversation, not a navigated GUI.

With conversational AI, a buyer accustomed to writing 'Can I get 12 of the 4-inch variant, net 30, shipping Tuesday?' now gets a system that can interpret the intent, apply structure, then generate a clean order. The buyer and supplier motions stay the same.

This is why B2B has fewer behavioral obstacles than consumer markets and more to gain from collapsing search, validation, and ordering into a single stream. The question is no longer whether this collapse will happen, but when. Three forces suggest the answer is now.

Section 5

The Inflection Point (2024-2027)

Three forces are converging: buyer behavior is shifting toward continuous interaction, core infrastructure has reached practical maturity, and supplier pressure is mounting. Two are at an inflection point and the third accelerates everything that follows.

We have established that B2B's inflection point is when buyer intent begins entering systems as structured data, rather than being reconstructed after the fact. B2B trade is entering a window where this shift becomes unavoidable. The transition is a result of three forces colliding at the same time: evolving buyer behavior, maturing infrastructure, and rising operational pressure across suppliers.

Together, they reset what buyers expect and what suppliers must deliver.

1. Buyer Behavior Is Moving Toward Continuous, Digital Interaction

The modern B2B buyer will work through messages, search inputs, and live clarification cycles. They expect visibility into availability, pricing, terms, and delivery timelines without rep-induced delays. The first wave of click-to-buy experiences, even in basic form, have set this new digital baseline. In Gartner's 2025 B2B survey, 61% of buyers preferred a rep-free buying experience, and 83% of buyers now prefer a digital ordering format.

A Wunderman Thompson survey of 600 B2B buyers in the US, UK , and China also found that 53% of buyers switched suppliers due to a poor ordering experience. This behavioral shift is consistent with increasing industry churn rates, and introduces new competitive pressures on the market; for a mid-market supplier with 1,000 accounts averaging $75k annually, a 53% churn risk represents $39 million in potential lost revenue.

Buyers are also becoming comfortable placing large orders through digital channels, historically a key barrier to portal adoption. In 2024, 39% of B2B buyers were willing to spend over $500,000 per order via self-service digital commerce, up from just 28% two years earlier (McKinsey). This marks a meaningful shift in purchasing behavior and expands the ceiling for digital transaction volume.

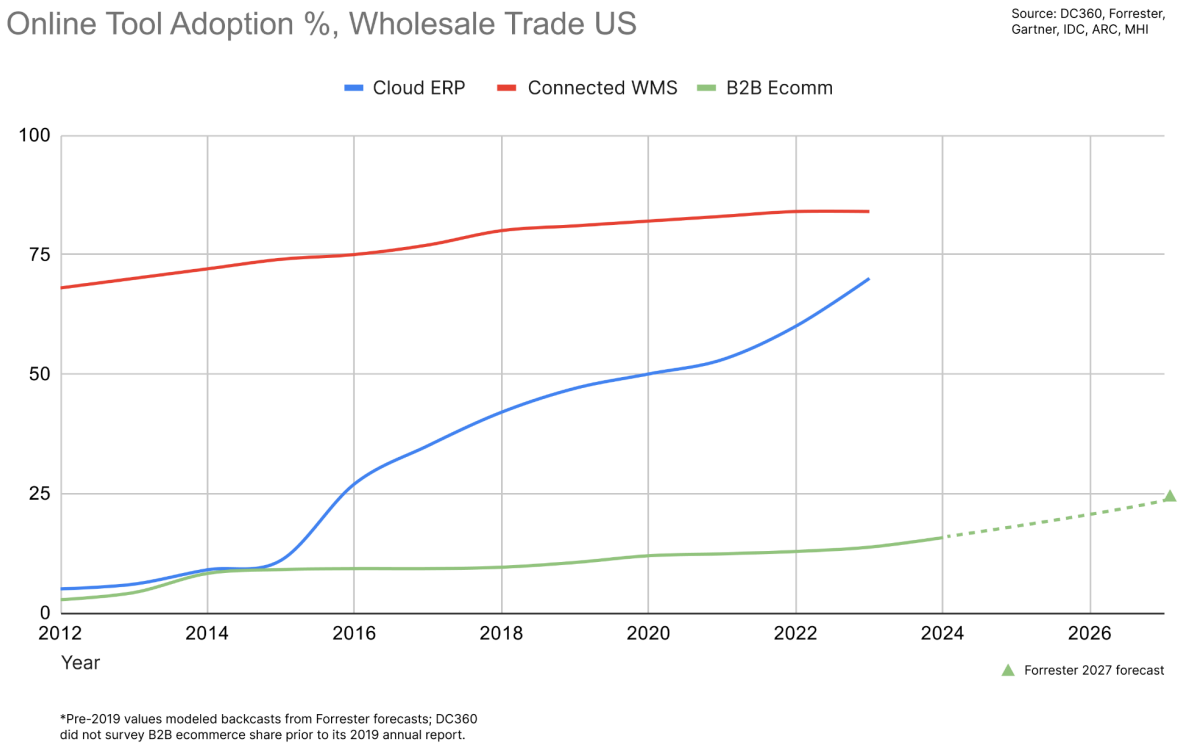
2. Core Infrastructure Has Reached Maturity

The technologies required for structured transactions have developed enough to support operational scale.

- AI ingestion can convert catalogs and pricing logic into machine-readable formats in minutes vs days.
- ERP APIs are universal enough to surface real-time inventory and apply supplier rules instantly.

- Embedded credit and automated finance rails can attach directly inside the order lifecycle.
- Conversational interfaces can translate natural buyer requests into structured data with human-level fidelity.

B2B's technology stack has been quietly maturing for years, while the POS remained offline.



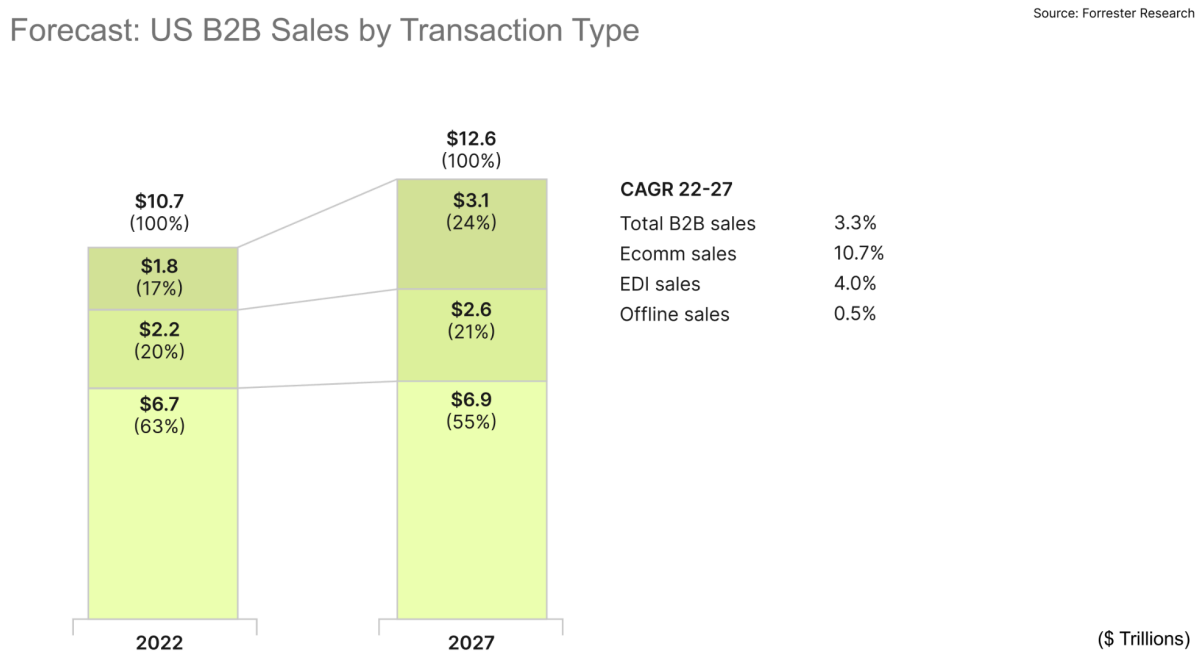
Examining the trend in Cloud ERP adoption is a useful analogy for why modernization in other parts of the stack did little to accelerate eCommerce ordering. Portal adoption is finally nearing 20%, even as downstream connected systems are the norm.

But now, buyers are beginning to convert through digital surfaces, and suppliers can measure the impact of response time, availability, and clarity in ways not possible before.

Between 2019 and 2023, B2B eCommerce's share of total U.S. B2B sales grew from 10.8% to 14%. During the same period, the market value grew at a 6.7% CAGR. Forrester forecasts adoption at 24% by 2027 – an acceleration to ~14% annual share growth, or roughly 2.1x the prior rate. As digital ordering surfaces accelerate, the suppliers who modernize gain a measurable Competitive Value Advantage, and that pressure changes the behavior of the entire market.

3. Supplier Pressure Is Increasing Across Every Operational Layer

A myriad of outside factors have also added pressure over the past decade. Suppliers face tighter margins, rising labor costs and growing customer expectations. Delays at the POS create delays in quoting, fulfillment, invoicing, and reconciliation that are now more expensive to resolve. Cycle times matter because buyers choose faster suppliers, and for suppliers, cash flow stability is more important than ever.



Manual workflows cannot keep pace with these pressures and suppliers are actively searching for systems that shorten the path from intent to confirmation, and from confirmation to settlement. Over the next 2 years, eCommerce portal growth will outpace both dominant transaction rails (EDI and Offline)

Convergence

The rising adoption of click-to-buy ordering is the clearest signal of this convergence. Digital ordering in B2B remained below twenty percent for more than a decade. It is climbing because each of the three forces pushes the market toward the same destination: faster validation and consistent logic within a single flow.

The conditions that are required for structured, real-time transactions are now in place, and the demand for them is rising from both sides of the market.

Section 6
Unlocking Offline Markets

Markets digitize in layers: efficiency, then financial, then competitive. B2B is on the threshold of unlocking the third.

The internet economy runs on structured transactions that systems can execute, measure, and extend. These transaction-driven markets unlock in three layers. Each layer emerges only when specific structural conditions exist, and each one compounds the value of the layer before it. This framework explains why B2B has stalled for decades and why it is entering a moment of acceleration now.

1. **Efficiency Value:** tools that remove operational friction. Fewer errors, handoffs, and time spent re-keying information between systems. Most B2B tooling lives here today. These tools deliver incremental value, but they exist in silos and don't compound. Efficiency value increases accuracy and speed, but it does not change buyer behavior or meaningfully expand digital adoption.
2. **Financial Value:** tools that directly increase revenue, velocity, predictability and cash efficiency. These systems make the infrastructure around them economically powerful, not just operationally efficient. Incentives also shift because the product isn't just saving time to generate more money. It's generating money without *any* additional time.
3. **Competitive Value:** a condition that emerges when a product gives one operator a measurable advantage over another. 'I can capture more customers because I have X and you do not.' When products reach this point, they absorb market share because participants can feel the performance delta. Reverting becomes impractical, creating structural lock-in. Competitive value changes behavior and this is what makes markets tip.

B2B has adopted the first layer, is now gaining the second, and is on the threshold of unlocking the third. This is why the market is entering an acceleration window. For the first time, the infrastructure exists to deliver all three layers as a unified system.

Section 7
Architecture of Trade in 2035

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By 2035, B2B transactions will be structured, financed, and reconciled in real time

Enterprise technology adoption typically takes 8-12 years from inflection point to default. If the inflection point is now, 2035 is not a precise prediction, but a likely horizon we can use to describe a full market shift.

Based on the current 14.5% CAGR, eCommerce portals will conservatively account for 70% of B2B sales by 2035. That 10-year trajectory near-perfectly mirrors cloud ERP adoption, which grew from roughly one-quarter of implementations in 2014 to two-thirds today.

B2B trade is moving toward a reality that no longer relies on fragmented communication and manual interpretation. Other transaction-driven industries predictably transformed under similar conditions.

- **Travel** transformed in 1964 when Sabre replaced manual phone-based airline reservations with a structured digital system. Booking time dropped from 90 minutes to seconds; within a year, the system handled 7,500 reservations per hour.
- **Accounting** shifted when systems adopted real-time AP/AR events. Invoice processing compressed from weeks to days as payment terms, settlement, and reconciliation drew from a shared transaction object.
- **Payments** became programmable when companies like Stripe reduced merchant onboarding from weeks of bank negotiations to a few lines of code. What previously required coordinating banks, gateways, and payment processors collapsed into a single transaction surface.
- **Retail** scaled digitally when product, pricing, inventory, and checkout logic converged into unified platforms like Shopify. This convergence allowed the entire sales lifecycle to be executed through a single interface.

In the case of B2B trade, two shifts are required for transformation.

1. Transactions Become Structured Digital Events

The catalog attributes, pricing tiers, terms, inventory positions, and fulfillment constraints that shape each order must be represented in a shared format. Buyer intent must be captured with enough fidelity for systems to interpret it directly. Every order must carry the logic required for downstream systems to act immediately (Section 3).

2. The POS Becomes a Continuous Flow

The buyer interacts through a single surface where questions, clarifications, configuration, and confirmation occur in one progression, and across multiple suppliers. The interface is

conversational because conversation reflects how B2B buyers already express intent today, so there won't be a major shift in user behavior (Section 4).

Both require a tool that translates every input into structured data in real time – likely an AI agent that converts conversations to order data which downstream systems can execute. This is how Competitive Value will emerge in the eCommerce landscape.

Section 8
Implications

Structured transactions reshape supplier economics, competition, and infrastructure. The operators who adopt early will outperform, and the rest will follow.

The shift to structured, real-time transactions will affect the layout of competition, and thus the overall shape of the B2B infrastructure market. Once buyer intent becomes machine-readable and the POS becomes continuous, the market will reorganize around the systems capable of interpreting and executing on that intent.

Supplier Economics

A structured POS compresses cycle time, reduces error rates, and shortens the path from commitment to cash. Suppliers gain clearer demand signals and accurate confirmation workflows, which make forecasting less reactive. Labor can be redeployed to revenue-generating activities like account nurture rather than reconstruction and data entry. Profitability will depend more on programmability than manual coordination.

Competition

Buyers naturally gravitate toward the operators whose workflows provide clarity and immediacy. As ordering becomes structured, suppliers will differentiate through these measurable outcomes. Early adopters of conversational ordering will gain a compounding advantage. And eventually, the market will transition from relationship-led to performance-led without removing the role of trust; trust simply attaches to reliability and speed rather than human-powered reassurance.

Infrastructure

The infrastructure landscape reorganizes once a structured POS becomes the coordination layer. Incumbent systems that operate as isolated modules now – ERP, WMS, invoicing, credit management, payment gateways, reconciliation tools – cannot compete as standalone solutions once operators expect end-to-end continuity. Tools that capture multiple events in a single flow will absorb an increasing share of the stack. As this happens, the B2B market will consolidate around unified ecosystems rather than fragmented utilities.

Lock-in

Once suppliers operate on structured rails, reverting becomes impractical. The gains in accuracy and speed are too large, and the workflows become encoded into user behavior. Finance expects a clean signal and buyers expect instant clarity. The architecture becomes default because operators who use it outperform and the rest must adapt

The online point of sale will mark the largest, and perhaps final, major workflow shift in B2B. Every previous wave of digitization, from payments to advertising, followed the same pattern: structured transactions became the foundation, and the market reorganized around whoever controlled them.

In 2035, every B2B transaction will be structured, financed, and reconciled in real time. Buyers will search, evaluate, and order through a single continuous flow. The market that resisted modernization for two decades will finally operate on programmable rails.

Sources

Definitions

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Section 1

Figure 1: "B2B Trade Volume Vast But Not Digitally Native"

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